are rarely due to neglect; instead, they reflect the reality that software systems grow incrementally and that access decisions must be made long before a comprehensive strategy is in place.

As organizations expand their digital ecosystems, the limitations of this localized approach become more obvious.

- **Employees face inconsistent behavior across products and services**—an engineer might be able to deploy code through one service but be blocked in another because each system enforces access rules differently.
- **Customers encounter confusing permission failures or delayed onboarding**—customers invited to collaborate on a document are able to view it but not comment or share it, with no clear explanation why.
- **Partners need custom integration work to achieve controlled delegation**—a partner integrating with an API may require custom logic to ensure it can act on behalf of a customer without being over-permissioned.
- **Automation initiatives reveal gaps in how authority is defined and limited**—an automated workflow might be able to trigger actions across systems but lack clear constraints on when or how those actions should be allowed.

These challenges often seem unrelated at first, but they share a common root: the surface area of authorization decisions has grown faster than the infrastructure used to manage them.

Figure 19.2 illustrates a common progression in how organizations respond to this pressure. Early efforts focus on embedding access logic directly within applications. As complexity grows, teams start to externalize decision logic to improve consistency and incorporate richer context signals. Over time, some organizations realize that authorization should be treated as a shared decision infrastructure that serves as a strategic capability to support delegation, automation, and ecosystem collaboration.